

Minecraft Sheep

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October 28, 2023

Abstract

valarante child game.... look to cartoon grapfix to make kid player happy like children show.. valarante cartoon world with rainbow unlike counter strike with dark corridorr and raelistic gun.. valarante like playhouse. valarant playor run from csgo fear of dark world and realism

1 Introduction

Minecraft is an open-world sandbox video game¹. The game takes place in a procedurally generated world made of cubic voxels, or *blocks*. Among other activities, players can engage in agriculture, including the raising of sheep. Sheep can be sheared sheared to gather wool, and require grass to eat to regrow their wool after shearing. Grass blocks are converted to dirt after being eaten, and may be converted back to grass by other adjacent grass blocks. If a pasture is packed too densely with sheep, they will deplete the grass, and wool production will be low. However, if the pasture is not densely packed, wool production will still be low because there are not many sheep. Between these two extremes, there is an optimal sheep population that will maximize wool output.

1.1 Deterministic vs. Stochastic

Shortly, we will seek a model for the population of grass in a pasture. The growth and consumption of grass is a stochastic process, like everything else in *Minecraft*, and also like population evolution in the real world. Early population models were deterministic, but more sophisticated and useful models are stochastic, incorporating the uncertainty inherent in population size. This paper will take the deterministic approach, owing to its simplicity².

1.2 A brief tangent about units

Canonically, one block is one cubic meter.

¹This investigation was conducted in Minecraft version 1.19.4.

²And the author's modest mathematical background.

2 Key assumptions and notes

There are a couple key assumptions being made here:

- Grass growth is a simple process in which all dirt blocks have an equal chance to turn into a grass block on a tick. This is not entirely realistic, since grass growth is contingent on spreading from an adjacent block, but as long as dirt blocks consistently have adjacent grass blocks it should work.
- The actual rate at which the farm produces wool is limited by the rate at which the farmer shears the sheep. Initially, we will assume the farmer is infinitely fast, so really the goal is to have the greatest rate of sheep eating grass. Later, we will look at the mechanics of a farm where the farmer harvests the wool at regular intervals.
- Another important thing to note is that pastures can be discussed in terms of *blocks* or *area*. One block is canonically one square meter, So pasture size has units of area. However, area in minecraft is discretized, i.e. you cannot have fractional area. For this reason, pasture area will be discussed using the unitless quantity *blocks*.

3 Model

3.1 Grass consumption by sheep

Sheep attempt to eat at a rate R [s^{-1}]. A sheep's attempt to eat will only succeed if it is standing on a grass block. A pasture containing N [unitless] sheep, whose surface is covered in grass with fraction X_g [unitless], will lose grass at a rate

$$NRX_g \tag{1}$$

as it is eaten by sheep. This assumes that the sheep are distributed uniformly so that the probability of any sheep standing on a grass block is equal to the grass cover of the pasture.

3.2 Grass growth

The rate at which grass grows not as simple. If X_g is small, then grass growth will be limited by the lack of places the grass can spread *from*. If X_g is close to 1, grass growth will be limited by a lack of places for the grass to spread *to*. We will employ a logistic model, where grass growth follows the differential equation:

$$\dot{y} = ky \left(1 - \frac{y}{p} \right)$$

Where k is a parameter representing the reproduction rate of the population and p is the carrying capacity, the maximum population that the local environment can sustain.

The logistic model is one of the oldest models for population growth. It was born from the older exponential (or *Malthusian*) model, but modified to include a maximum population size. It is useful as a tool of instruction, but it's not very useful for modelling actual populations, and has since been supplanted by more sophisticated models. However, we are not dealing with an actual population, but rather a video game which has simple population mechanics. Therefore the model is appropriate for our purposes. We will employ the following equation for grass growth:

$$\dot{X}_g = kX_g(1 - X_g)$$

Where k [s^{-1}] is a constant as described above. The carrying capacity is 1 because naturally, the pasture cannot be more than 100% covered in grass.

Let's define the pasture size A [unitless]. If we multiply the above equation by A , we can express the rate of change of the total grass area rather than the grass cover:

$$A\dot{X}_g = kAX_g(1 - X_g) \quad (2)$$

3.3 The fast farmer

If the pasture reaches equilibrium, the rate at which the sheep eat should be equal to the rate at which the grass is regrowing. We can express this, by combining (1) and (2), as

$$NRX_g = A\dot{X}_g = kAX_g(1 - X_g)$$

This expression is important because it gives us the equilibrium grass cover as a function of sheep population - a little algebra gives

$$X_g = 1 - \frac{NR}{Ak} \quad (3)$$

Plugging this into our logistic model for grass growth (2) gives

$$A\dot{X}_g = NR - \frac{N^2R^2}{Ak}$$

This is the steady-state grass regrowth rate as a function of sheep population. If the farmer is shearing sheep as quickly as they get their wool, they are getting 1 block of wool for every block of grass the sheep eat. Let's define F [s^{-1}] as the rate at which the farmer gathers wool.

$$F_{fast} = A\dot{X}_g = NR - \frac{N^2R^2}{Ak} \quad (4)$$

We can find the maximum by differentiating (4) with respect to N , setting the derivative to 0 and solving for N :

$$\begin{aligned}\frac{dF_{fast}}{dN} &= R - \frac{2NR^2}{Ak} = 0 \\ N &= \frac{Ak}{2R}\end{aligned}\tag{5}$$

According to the assumptions we've made, this is the sheep population that will produce the maximum rate of grass growth. At this population,

$$F_{fast} = \frac{Ak}{4}$$

3.4 The realistically slow farmer

For the case of the infinitely fast farmer, the rate at which wool is harvested is the same as the rate at which the sheep are eating. To account for the farmer being slow, we'll need to think a bit more.

The farmer is off doing other things, and every T seconds, they come back to shear the sheep. Upon shearing the sheep, all the sheep are wool-less. By the time they come back for the next shearing, the sheep have regrown some amount of wool. Let's say the number of sheep that have their wool is N_w [unitless]. So when the farmer shears the sheep, they get N_w wool. Then the average rate at which the farmer gathers wool is

$$F_{slow} = \frac{N_w}{T}$$

Now we need to consider the value of N_w . A sheep will only regrow wool upon eating if it doesn't already have any, so we should expect that the rate at which sheep are regrowing wool is the rate at which they are eating, NRX_g , times the fraction of sheep that are wool-less:

$$\dot{N}_w = \frac{dN_w}{dt} = \frac{N - N_w}{N} NRX_g = (N - N_w)RX_g$$

At time $t = 0$, the farmer shears all the sheep, leaving them with $N_w = 0$, and then at time $t = T$, the farmer comes back and shears them again, gathering N_w blocks of wool. How many sheep grew their wool back in time T [s]? We can find out by solving the above equation for N_w . We'll separate it into N_w terms and non N_w terms:

$$\frac{1}{N - N_w} dN_w = (RX_g)dt$$

and integrate from initial state ($t = 0, N_w = 0$) to the final state ($t = T, N_w = N_w(T)$). We're assuming the pasture has reached steady state, so X_g is independent of t and can be treated as a constant.

$$\int_0^{N_w(T)} \frac{1}{N - N_w} dw = \int_0^T RX_g dt$$

$$-\ln\left(\frac{N - N_w(T)}{N}\right) = TRX_g$$

And solve for $N_w(T)$:

$$N_w(T) = N(1 - e^{-TRX_g})$$

So when the farmer comes back to shear the sheep at $t = T$, they will get $N - Ne^{-TRX_g}$ blocks of wool. If the farmer keeps coming back every T seconds, they will be gathering wool at a rate

$$F_{slow} = \frac{N(1 - e^{-TRX_g})}{T}$$

Finally, we can plug (3) for X_g :

$$F_{slow} = \frac{N\left(1 - e^{-TR(1 - \frac{RN}{Ak})}\right)}{T} \quad (6)$$

This is the expression for the rate of wool gathering by a slow farmer. The optimal density of sheep is now dependent on T . To find the optimal sheep population, we can take the same approach as we did with the fast farmer case. Differentiating (6) w.r.t. N :

$$\frac{dF}{dN} = \frac{1 - \left(\frac{TR^2N}{Ak} + 1\right)e^{-TR + \frac{TR^2N}{Ak}}}{T} = 0$$

Attempting to solve for N leads to

$$\left(\frac{TR^2N}{Ak} + 1\right)e^{\frac{TR^2N}{Ak} + 1} = e^{TR+1}$$

At this point we must invoke the lambert W function, a nonelementary function satisfying

$$W(x)e^{W(x)} = x$$

applying this leads to

$$W(e^{TR+1}) = \frac{TR^2N}{Ak} + 1$$

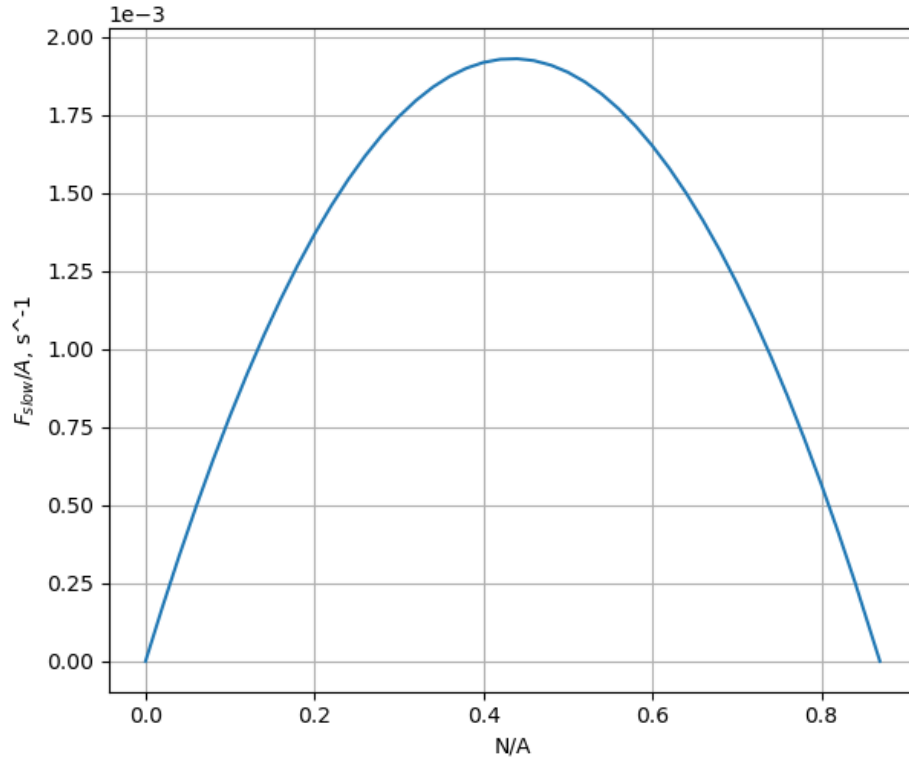
$$N = \frac{Ak}{TR^2}(W(e^{TR+1}) - 1) \quad (7)$$

Plugging this back into (6), we get

$$F_{slow} = \frac{Ak(W(e^{TR+1}) - 1)(1 - e^{-TR + W(e^{TR+1}) - 1})}{R^2T^2}$$

4 Model Discussion

Figure 1: Plot of $\frac{F_{fast}}{A}$ as a function of N .



If we plug (5) back into (3), our expression for equilibrium grass cover, we get $g = 0.5$. This should make sense - the derivative of the logistic function is maximum when $f(x) = 0.5$.

Let's also note that there is a certain population of sheep for which the equilibrium grass cover is zero:

$$N = \frac{Ak}{R}$$

We can employ the following approximation, for small x :

$$e^x - 1 \approx x$$

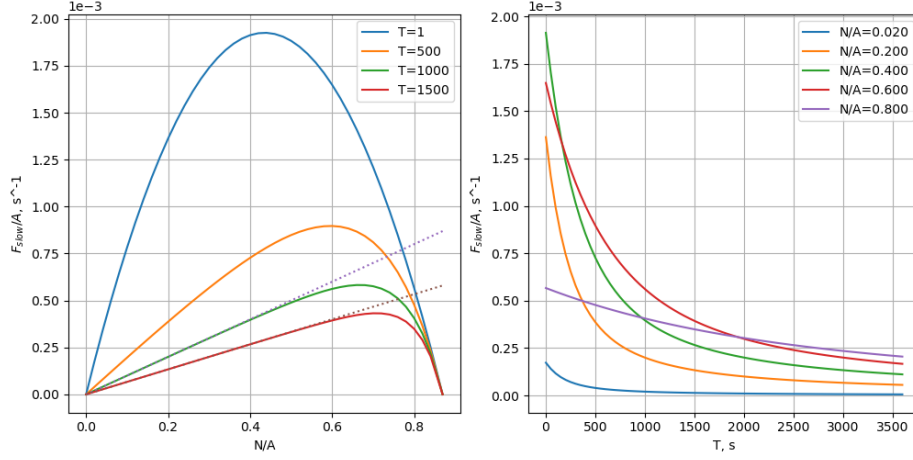
to see that for small values of T , $F_{slow} \approx F_{fast}$:

$$F_{slow} \approx NR - \frac{N^2 R^2}{Ak} = F_{fast}$$

For large values of T and modest values of N , $e^{-TR(1-\frac{RN}{Ak})} \approx 0$, and so

$$F_{slow} \approx \frac{N}{T}$$

Figure 2: Plots of $\frac{F_{slow}}{A}$ as a function of N and T.



5 Experimental Work

Now what? It seems like we have the answer we wanted, but what about k and R ? we need to know the actual rate at which sheep eat, and the rate at which grass grows.

The user-maintained minecraft wiki says that sheep have a 1/1000 chance of attempting to eat on every other tick (a tick being 1/20 of a second). With ten chances per second at a probability of 1/1000, the expected value is 0.01. So we can estimate that $R = 0.01$. However, this is based on data from a user-operated wiki with no citation standards and questionable accountability. So we will be conducting an in-game experiment to determine R .

The grass mechanics are sufficiently complicated that it will also be easier for us to set up an experiment in-game to estimate the logistic growth parameters.

5.1 Sheep eating experiment

Determining R is not terribly difficult. We can simply set a timer and count how many times a sheep eats within that time.

Counting the number of times the sheep eats is done as follows. The sheep is put in a 1x1 block enclosure, standing on a grass block. Facing the grass block is an observer. The observer is connected to a dropper, full of items and facing a chest. When the sheep eats the grass, it turns into dirt, activating the observer and causing an item to be placed in the chest. The number of times the sheep eats is counted by the number of items in the chest.

The observer is also connected to a command block, which is set to place a grass block under the sheep using `/setblock`. When the sheep eats the grass block, turning it into dirt, the command block will immediately replace the dirt with another grass block, ensuring that the sheep is always standing on grass.

Ten of these sheep cells were allowed to run for 1 hour. The experiment was started and stopped using command blocks to `/summon` and `/kill` sheep in all cells simultaneously.

In one hour, the sheep consumed 320 blocks of grass. This gives an R value of 0.00888 s^{-1} .

5.2 Grass growth experiment

Determining k is a little more complicated than R. The idea with this experiment is to begin with a large area of dirt with uniformly distributed grass blocks, and allow it to spread while recording the grass cover at regular intervals.

The experiment was set up as follows. A 30x30 flat plot of dirt, isolated from any other nearby dirt and grass blocks, was partially covered in grass in this pattern:

6 Simulations

Finally, to validate all this math and get some actual insight into the sheep and their activities, we will be constructing first-principles simulations of grazing sheep.